



Say Cheese!

Whether you're a shutterbug who wants a digital camera to share photos online or you're seriously interested in digital photography, this test will help you make the right choice

We see it all around us—budget home theatre systems, fast computers on easy instalments and dirt cheap cell phones that are now being used by even your local *paanwala*! Riding on this wave of widespread acceptance of technology products by the masses is another category—digital cameras.

Not too long ago, digital cameras were outrageously expensive and out of reach for the average shutterbug. Even with its long-term benefits and convenience, the price proved to be a big stumbling block. With the advancement of technology, prices have fallen, bringing a wide range of digital cameras that suit everyone—from the most basic digital cameras that allow you to video-conference, to those that strike a good balance between imaging capabilities and features, all the way to the big guys that offer brilliant optics and professional level imaging performance.

Digital cameras are fast catching up with their conventional counterparts in terms of

imaging capability and there will be a time in the not-too-distant future when photography will completely transit into the digital realm. While these high-performance cameras are still beyond the reach of most of us, they are certainly more affordable than they were, say, about a year ago. Most basic level digital cameras then sported specifications like 1-megapixel CCDs; today, you can easily find 2-megapixel cameras for the same price. With the proliferation of broadband Internet access, digital cameras are the coolest devices to effortlessly capture and transmit those memorable moments. Imagine taking a photo of your little baby when it takes its first stumbling steps and e-mailing it to your relatives halfway around the world or posting it on your Web site, all within the matter of a few minutes!

All these factors, coupled with some truly cool features such as the capability to record movie clips, apply special effects to images from the camera itself, and their immense user-friendliness and pocket-sized form factors have made these devices great fun to use, at the same time giving you superb quality photographs.

Digit Test Process

Qualification criteria

We reviewed cameras in two categories: those with a CCD rating of under 2 megapixels and those between 2 to 3.5 megapixels. However, in the 2+ megapixel category, most of the cameras supported a CCD rating between 2 and 2.3 megapixels—only two cameras in this category offered a CCD rating higher than 3 megapixels. These were the Nikon